

From the vault: Former India captain Bhaichung Bhutia won the Santosh Trophy twice with Bengal in 1995 and 1999. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

title in alternate years for the first time since 2005.

In the latest edition, almost all the players were amateur footballers. Phijam Sanathoi Meetei, the highest goal-scorer in the tournament, had changed clubs four times in three years after being released by the reserve side of the Kerala Blasters.

S. Rajesh, who became the fifth-highest goal-scorer in the Santosh Trophy, was once a dependable attacking option for Gokulam Kerala.

The COVID-infused break and Railways' continued absence from the National Championships saw him struggle for a spot in the GKFC squad. The 31-year-old, a record-holder in the Santosh Trophy, now plays for Rail Wheel Factory FC Bangalore, a club outside the top three divisions of Indian football: the Indian Super League (ISL), I-League, and I-League 2.

Once considered a prestigious crown in domestic football, the Santosh Trophy has transformed into a showcase for amateur and struggling players.

Fall from grace

Santosh Trophy's biggest challenge arrived late in the 20th century when the National Football League (NFL) was started by the All India Football Federation (AIFF) in 1996, the first organised nationwide league football system in the country.

India's national team players continued to play in both tournaments as part of state federations and clubs.

Former India captain Bhaichung Bhutia won the Santosh Trophy with Bengal in 1995 and 1999.

I. M. Vijayan, another former national skipper, won consecutive Santosh Trophy titles in 1993 and 1994 with Kerala and Bengal, respectively. He played for Kerala Police and Mohun Bagan, both of whom eventually played in the NFL.

Vijayan and Bhaichung continued



to represent Kerala and Bengal, respectively, with the former reaching the final five more times with his home state (1987-88, 1988-89, 1989-90, 1990-91, 1999-2000).

However, the NFL, which was later rebranded as the I-League in 2007, eventually gained preference for national team players and administrators of Indian football.

"I wouldn't personally play in the Santosh Trophy. It should be converted into an age-group event. It should also be mandatory for national players to participate in the NFL and Fed Cup, which has now been replaced by the Kalinga Super Cup," Bhaichung said in an interview in 2007.

The death knell arrived in 2010 when it became a subject of disdain for the then-national team coach Bob Houghton.

The Englishman who had previously taken Malmo to the Champions League final (1979) was apoplectic when Delhi's captain Sunil Chhetri, then a young quick forward attracting offers from clubs in England and the USA, was injured (right ankle) in a clash against Indian

Railways (in May 2009), ruling him out of the Nehru Cup.

"If you are serious about qualifying for the World Cup, then you should forget playing nonsensical and stupid tournaments like the Santosh Trophy, Durand Cup, and the IFA Shield," Houghton said in a press conference.

"Professionals playing the Santosh Trophy against a bunch of amateurs at the end of the season doesn't make any sense. Do you believe Steven Gerrard will play for some hotchpotch trophy at the end of the season?"

On January 29, 2010, the AIFF ruled that the national team players were barred from the tournament.

Talking to *Sportstar*, Satheevan Balan, a former scout for the Indian national team, elaborated on the events that further deteriorated the status of the Santosh Trophy.

"Whenever the I-league players were available, Goa and Bengal had an advantage over other teams in the Santosh Trophy," said Balan, the coach of Kerala in the last edition of the tournament.

"Following complaints, the AIFF decided to turn the Santosh Trophy

Santosh Trophy champions in the 1962 Asian Games squad

No	Name	
1	Peter Thangaraj	1960-61 (Services), 1962-63 (Bengal), 1964-65 (Railways)
2	Chuni Goswami	1955-56, 1958-59 (Bengal)
3	P. K. Banerjee	1958-59 (Bengal), 1961-62, 1966-67 (Railways)
4	D. Ethiraj	1960-61 (Services)
5	Tulsidas Balaram	1956-57 (Hyderabad), 1958-59, 1959-60, 1962-63 (Bengal)
6	Pradyut Barman	1958-59, 1959-60 (Bengal), 1961-62 (Railways)